To: **David Wilson, PhD, Principal Investigator, Dean and Professor, Goldman School of Public Policy and Department of Political Science, UC Berkeley**
From: **Robert Cordova, Research Assistant**
Re: **PPAD Research Note on Human Flourishing and Civic/Political Efficacy**
Date: **August 19th, 2025**

Introduction

The Political Psychology of American Democracy (PPAD) Project studies attitudes, beliefs, and opinions about American democracy along with social and political psychological factors that can either strengthen or weaken it. The project is housed within the Democracy Policy Lab and the Goldman School of Public Policy and is funded by the Hewlett Foundation. This note investigates the relationship in the PPAD dataset between human flourishing (HF) — as a standardized composite scale derived from seven HF variables measured on Likert scales — and two sets of efficacy variables also on Likert scales.

The HF variables include five for internal drive (i.e., happiness, meaning, purpose, character, and virtue) and two for external well-being (i.e., financial and material stability). The political efficacy items address, respectively, having a good understanding of issues, knowledge of politics, the belief that public officials don't care about what people think, and access to information to participate in American democracy. The civic efficacy items address capacities to research, organize, discuss a newspaper article, and listen to contrasting opinions. The larger aim here involves considering what democracy policies can bolster civic flourishing, discussed below.

Literature Review and Hypothesis

Lühr, M. et al. (2022) provide a panel study analysis suggesting that political volunteering in Germany increases internal political efficacy and ultimately boosts emotional well-being and life satisfaction. Fenn, N. et al. (2021) examines how civic engagement in the United States impacts service self efficacy and then well-being — with attention to gender. With a larger sample, Fenn, N et al (2023) reproduces a similar endeavor — again using civic self efficacy as a mediator for well-being. McSorley, A. et al (2023) examines internal political efficacy and self-rated health among Americans and Latinx subgroups (although the results are inverse among Puerto Ricans). We hypothesize a positive relationship between HF and efficacy.

Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 focuses on HF composite variable and the efficacy variables. HHF = 1 indicates a dichotomous variable for whether HF_Scale is high (i.e., greater than or equal to 0.8) takes an affirmative value. These means are survey weighted. Except for the third political efficacy variable, the efficacy means under high HF conditioning are higher than those of the full population. This exception, noted in a May 2025 PPAD report, deserves more attention and persists across the analyses below.

Table 1	wave 1				wave 2				wave 3			
obs. / x̄	all		HHF = 1		all		HHF = 1		all		HHF = 1	
HF_Scale	2634	0.73	1096	0.87	3045	0.73	1300	0.88	2749	0.729	1155	0.88
POLEFFA1_1	2676	3.60	1090	3.77	3098	3.54	1295	3.74				
POLEFFA1_2	2678	3.06	1091	3.21	3098	3.08	1294	3.20				
POLEFFA1_3	2675	3.55	1091	3.41	3095	3.61	1295	3.47	2792	3.55	1150	3.39
POLEFFA1_4	2677	3.44	1090	3.61	3095	3.37	1295	3.61	2786	3.436	1148	3.50
CITZEFF1_1	2672	3.22	1091	3.28								
CITZEFF1_2	2671	2.84	1091	2.96								
CITZEFF1_3	2673	3.11	1091	3.18								
CITZEFF1_4	2670	3.29	1091	3.37								

Methods and Models

We use Pearson correlations to consider linear relationships between the HF variable and both political and civic efficacy and follow up with OLS regressions. The correlations in Table 2 rely on unweighted values given constraints in the Stata package. The unweighted correlations do not produce concern as we can rely on weighted regressions. The regressions in Table 3, on page 3, rely on weighted values and control for age, income, gender (2 = female), race (1 = White identifying), urban residence (1 = yes), college education (1 = yes), and affiliation (1 = non-Republican).

Results

HF correlates positively with all efficacy variables at the 95% confidence level except political efficacy item three; civic efficacy correlations exhibit lower magnitudes. The same results persist in regression with some nuances.

Table 2	wave 1			wave 2			wave 3				wave 1		
corr. with HF_Scale	obs.	r	p	obs.	r	p	obs.	r	p		obs.	r	p
POLEFFA1_1	3032	0.16	0.000	3031	0.20	0.000				CITZEFF1_1	3027	0.07	0.000
POLEFFA1_2	3032	0.13	0.000	3031	0.12	0.000				CITZEFF1_2	3022	0.07	0.000
POLEFFA1_3	3029	-0.18	0.000	3032	-0.14	0.000	2910	-0.14	0.000	CITZEFF1_3	3024	0.08	0.000
POLEFFA1_4	3032	0.17	0.000	3030	0.24	0.000	2906	0.22	0.000	CITZEFF1_4	3024	0.06	0.001

Although coefficients appear small in magnitude, they represent meaningful effects when interpreted relative to the HF scale range. With the political efficacy item one in wave 2, for instance, a one-unit rise in efficacy (i.e., one-unit increase in the Likert scale) produces 0.02 in the HF composite scale. That represents 1/50 of the entire scale; theoretically if a survey participant exhibits three units of increase across similar efficacy variables, such increases constitute about 1/17 of the entire scale.

Table 3

HF on PE	wave 1 coeff.	wave 1 SE	wave 1 p	wave 2 coeff.	wave 2 SE	wave 2 p	wave 3 coeff.	wave 3 SE	wave 3 p
POLEFFA1_1	0.01	0.01	0.083	0.02	0.01	0.000			
POLEFFA1_2	0.00	0.00	0.685	-0.01	0.00	0.024			
POLEFFA1_3	-0.02	0.00	0.000	-0.02	0.00	0.000	-0.01	0.00	0.000
POLEFFA1_4	0.01	0.00	0.097	0.02	0.00	0.000	0.02	0.00	0.000
obs	2395			2393			2201		
R-squared	0.154			0.168			0.155		
p	0.000			0.00			0.000		

HF on CE	wave 1 coeff.	wave 1 SE	wave 1 p
CITZEFF1_1	0.00	0.01	0.628
CITZEFF1_2	0.01	0.00	0.138
CITZEFF1_3	0.01	0.01	0.004
CITZEFF1_4	0.00	0.01	0.629
obs	2396		
R-squared	0.137		
p	0.000		

HF on both	wave 1 coeff.	wave 1 SE	wave 1 p
POLEFFA1_1	0.01	0.01	0.144
POLEFFA1_2	0.00	0.00	0.937
POLEFFA1_3	-0.02	0.00	0.000
POLEFFA1_4	0.01	0.00	0.071
CITZEFF1_1	0.00	0.01	0.352
CITZEFF1_2	0.01	0.00	0.180
CITZEFF1_3	0.01	0.01	0.020
CITZEFF1_4	0.01	0.01	0.323
obs	2386		
R-squared	0.163		
p	0.000		

The coefficients remain stable in the full eight efficacy variable model for wave 1 although the p-values shift in favor of the civic efficacies variable. The log titled simple.log includes the results on the demographic control coefficients. Income and party affiliation have statistically significant coefficients where the former is consistently positive and small and latter is consistently negative and also small.

Discussion

One core competency stands out in facilitation of the good life that human flourishing represents. The coefficient of political efficacy item four — the self-reported belief in information access to participate in American democracy with confidence — is statistically significant at the 99th confidence level in wave 2 and 3, and at the 90th confidence level in wave 1. It also persists into the full eight-variable model, though only at 90% confidence level. Political efficacy item one (i.e. understanding of issues) also exhibits very high significance in wave 2. Meanwhile, civic efficacy item three (i.e., newspaper discourse) in wave 1 also constitutes a reliable competency though with less magnitude in both the simple and full models.

The negative coefficient for political efficacy item three (i.e., whether public officials care) is the most consistent finding in this research note. In conjunction with political efficacy item four, the

May 2025 report describes this condition as a "conflict between the inputs and outputs necessary for a well-functioning democracy"(21).

Another large question is why political efficacy exhibits more reliable patterns than civic efficacy. Perhaps the political efficacy survey questions are more theoretical and interpretive, while the civic efficacy questions are more contextual and practical. The latter include clear and present obstacles that might obstruct their completion.

Limitations and Future Work

One immediate goal surfaces — to repeat this analysis with each individual HF variable to identify more granular estimates that the HF index may conceal. And to do the same granular analysis for Spanish speakers given the insights from McSorley, A. et al (2023). The income and party affiliation effects also may offer new questions. Delving deeper into the political efficacy item three also seems fruitful. We also want to determine ways to address concerns of reverse causality.

Civic flourishing produces conditions where American democracy enjoys greater participation, shared purpose, and well-being as embodied in social networks, belonging, and the capacity for collective action. A future analysis will include a better literature review for structure and nature of the good life within American democracy. The May 2025 PPAD report considers these questions more directly.

Sources

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